



So close: India's Quimcy Joaquim Dsouza controls the ball during the women's singles bronze-medal teqball match against Japan's Yuina Sakamoto. The Indian lost the match and finished fourth. AP

China, demand was so extraordinary that esports was the only Asian Games sport for which tickets initially had to be distributed through a lottery. Reports at the time said millions applied for the chance to buy tickets for the 4,000-seat Hangzhou Esports Centre. This time there are 11 esports titles on the Asian Games programme.

This constant reinvention is hardly new.

The Asian Games has always had room for sporting curiosities. Bodybuilding has awarded Asian Games medals in 2002 and '06. So have cue sports (1998, 2002, '06 and '10). Ten-pin bowling survived on the programme for decades. Jet skiing and paragliding appeared in Jakarta in 2018. Pencak silat, the Indonesian martial art, had its moment there too. Dragon boat racing (2010, '18 and '22) has come and gone, as have chess and bridge. Soft tennis has also had a long association with the Asian Games.

That is why the Asian Games should never become merely an Asian version of the Olympics. Its eccentricities are its strength.

The Games are perhaps the world's greatest sporting expression of a continent's diversity.

Kabaddi has been India's ambassador to the Games. It entered the medal programme in 1990, and Indian men went on to win seven consecutive gold medals. Women's kabaddi arrived in 2010 and India won the first two titles. Only in Jakarta in 2018 was the script torn up, with Iran breaking India's dominance. India reclaimed both men's and women's gold medals in Hangzhou.

This raises an intriguing question.

What else can India bring to this wonderful Asian

sporting bazaar?

There is already a serious push for yogasana. The Indian Olympic Association formally sought yoga's inclusion in the Asian Games, and the OCA subsequently moved towards recognising it as an official sport. India also has a remarkable catalogue of indigenous disciplines — mallakhamb, kalaripayattu, gatka, thang-ta, kho-kho and silambam — already being promoted through Khelo India.

Why shouldn't some of them dream of an Asian Games future?

Imagine mallakhamb, with athletes performing extraordinary feats of strength and balance around a vertical wooden pole, before an international audience. Or kalaripayattu, one of India's oldest martial traditions.

There will inevitably be arguments about what constitutes a sport, how widespread it must be and whether an already enormous Asian Games programme can accommodate still more events. Those are legitimate questions. Aichi-Nagoya has 43 sports and 469 medal events.

But there is something wonderfully democratic about a Games where a sport does not have to be globally ubiquitous before it is allowed to matter.

Perhaps that is the greatest charm of the Asian Games. It does not merely tell us who the best athletes in Asia are. Every four years, it opens a window onto the different cultures and sporting traditions this vast continent shelters — preserving the quirks and identities that make Asia unique in an increasingly homogenised world.